

seems possible without him. This, indeed, amounts to a sweet revenge for the beleaguered Soren, who, the Congress thought, was unworthy of aligning with. Soren—who, at least twice, bailed out Congress governments at the Centre (once infamously during P.V. Narasimha Rao's regime) and who was once the most pampered politician of Jharkhand since undivided Bihar days—was left alone prior to the polls. The party, instead, stitched an alliance with Soren's bitter critic Babulal Marandi of Jharkhand Vikash Morcha (JVM). The Congress wrote him off because the JVM had lost heavily in the Lok Sabha polls with three of its sitting MPs biting the dust.

Indeed, since July 2004, politics has been a roller-coaster ride for Soren. During the last five years, he is perhaps the only politician in the country, who has resigned under duress thrice as Union minister and twice as chief minister. "I am open to possibilities and the BJP is not untouchable to us," Soren said a day before the counting began. Now he is keeping his cards close to his chest, as his negotiators are bracing up with both the NDA and UPA lieutenants for the one "best deal". Clearly, Soren now wants to have one more shot at the chief minister's chair before he hangs his battle-scarred boots. On personal front, he has been weakened by the death of his elder son, Durga Soren.

Though the Congress has begun sending open feelers to Soren, it will not be easy for it to cement a smooth deal as its partner JVM draws its strength from opposing the JMM. Soren and Marandi have common strongholds and both appear desperate to squeeze the other out of their political spaces. Marandi may, therefore, not find it easy to back Soren. The NDA will also have to surmount traditional hurdles and show a very large heart to embrace Soren.



GEETA KODA'S VICTORY SHOWS VOTERS WILL OVERLOOK CORRUPTION FOR A BETTER LIFE

Once JMM decides its course of action, All Jharkhand Students Union chief Sudesh Mahto with five MLAs may also have a say in the government formation. Lalu Prasad's RJD, which is experiencing the law of diminishing returns—from nine MLAs in Jharkhand after 2000 polls held during the undivided Bihar days, to seven in 2005 polls, to five now—is eager to snuggle up to the Congress. Lalu could well be hoping the Congress to accept his support in Jharkhand only to be forced to reciprocate later in Bihar.

The results, however, appear in sync with Jharkhand's record of having seen six chief ministers, besides more than six months of President's Rule in nine years of the state's existence. A period of factitious coalition building is

once again on the cards. Whoever occupies the top chair, the government would remain beset by partners. The election results, however, have thrown up plenty of nuanced messages to mainstream political parties. The one big message is that the voters in Jharkhand have refused to be taken for granted while rejecting the NDA's claim of viability. In fact, the BJP and its ally JD(U) clearly failed to capitalise on the anti-incumbency sentiment that was evident—against the two UPA-backed governments led by Soren and Madhu Koda—to a large measure. Largely because of a clear lack of coordination, mistrust and open bickering, they could not inspire confidence as credible political alternatives.

The BJP's loss is indeed very big,

**Among 20 Major States,
Jharkhand stands
19th on overall rankings**

Unstable governments have made administration a casualty and

AGRICULTURE

19th

PRIMARY
HEALTH

16th

INVESTMENT
ENVIRONMENT

12th

PRIMARY
EDUCATION

18th